

Hithium — Team-Lead Playbook

The sales leader's working document: demand-pool coverage, the policy calendar, competitive rules of engagement, and forecast discipline

Prepared 24 August 2026 · **Sources** hithium.profile.json profileVersion 5 · the relationship-web deliverable · the three Industry Guidance analyses · **Companion** hithium-ic-playbook.md, which carries the account-level motions

Sourcing Market facts trace to the dossier base and the guidance claims ledgers; analytical reads are labelled as reads · **Classification** Internal — sales strategy

PRESENTATION STYLE — BloombergNEF Research Report, the canonical Profiler export skin. Facts lead, labelled analysis follows, and the two never blur.

Provenance: Phase 4 deliverable of the AIDC program — synthesized from the 88-company Profiler dossier base, hithium.profile.json (profileVersion 5, the AIDC lens), the relationship-web deliverable (hithium-relationship-web.md), and the three Industry Guidance analyses (china-policy-stack-analysis.md, utility-aidc-procurement-analysis.md, bess-bankability-certification-analysis.md). Internal, never deployed. Companion: hithium-ic-playbook.md, which carries the account-level motions this document allocates. Prepared 2026-08-24.

Who this is for: the US sales leader setting territory, coverage posture, forecast discipline, and competitive rules of engagement for 2026-28. Market facts trace to the dossier base and the guidance claims ledgers; analytical judgments are labelled as reads.

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1. The thesis — where the money actually is

Three judgments anchor everything below:

1. **Queue gigawatts are not demand.** ERCOT carries ~474 GW of large-load requests against an ~86 GW all-time peak; AEP fields ~190 GW of inquiries on a 37 GW system. The single best proof of what's real: AEP Ohio's large-load tariff collapsed a 30 GW pipeline to ~5.6 GW of signed, financially committed load. The team's true pipeline signal is **certified MW** — IRP dockets and certification orders convert to purchase orders on a 12-36-month fuse. Sell where the money is certified, not where the queue is loud.

2. **The policy fence concentrates our US demand into two lanes plus a watchlist.** Safe-harbored 2025 starts and merchant/tax-indifferent buyers are addressable now; the regulated Southeast's certified programs — the actual growth story — are effectively fenced off from Chinese cells on prudence and FEOC grounds. Structure coverage to harvest the open lanes hard while building the long-game relationships in the fenced one.
3. **We assess (from the dossier, high confidence) that the AIDC category's US terms are being set by ON.energy, not by us** — and (moderate confidence) that financing, not demand, is Hithium's global constraint. Both cut the same way: the US book must be low-drama, reference-grade, and collections-clean. A small book of flawless accounts outperforms a large book of contested ones — the US operation's job is to be the credibility exhibit in the next financing story.

The orienting rule the ICs carry — *sell to the grid, not to the data centre* — is also the territory rule: the AI buildout pays us through utility- and IPP-owned front-of-meter storage, not through the data hall.

2. The six demand pools — coverage plan

POOL	2026-28 CHARACTER	POSTURE	COVERAGE
1 · Safe-harbored 2025 projects	Finite, depleting, builds through ~2028-29; the only ITC-compatible Hithium demand; the Jupiter book sits here	Primary	Dedicated hunters. This pool is a <i>list, not a market</i> — enumerate it, name every owner, and work the list to exhaustion. Urgency is the strategy: every quarter the list only shrinks
2 · Merchant ERCOT	~16.3 GW fleet (Jul 2026), growth decelerating (queue entries ~50% H2 2025), but tax-indifferent — our incumbent lane	Primary	Core account teams. Economics + availability + augmentation; the no-remote-access security architecture leads every Texas conversation
3 · Regulated Southeast / PJM certified	The growth story — Georgia 3,022.5 MW owned BESS certified + a 500 MW third-party RFP; Virginia's 2.7 GW mandate; Entergy Louisiana's first BESS RFP; PSO/SWEPCO 4.5 GW all-source — but a bankability world, effectively fenced	Watch	No quota. Relationship coverage only: EPC approved-vendor lists, IE relationships, bid-stage design-wins with developers on safe-harbored or non-ITC structures. Track every RFP calendar
4 · BtM data-center buffering	New and code-driven (NOGRR 282 / SB 6 curtailment); contested by ON.energy's FEOC-clean AI UPS category	Selective	Qualify hard; assume designed-out of US hyperscale specs. Realistic wins: non-US campuses, operators without ITC/FEOC exposure
5 · Gas-bridge storage attach	VoltaGrid / ERock / ProEnergy / Mainspring campuses all carry open storage sockets that fill post-bridge (~2029+); FEOC optics point them at non-Chinese cells	Watch	Standing watch, no quota. Track through their customers' owners; revisit if the policy stack moves
6 · Non-US	The open field — the current order book (Saudi, Ukraine, APAC, EU) already lives here; the product ladder competes unfenced	Per structure	Coordinate with global coverage; the US team's contribution is reference quality and fleet data, not account ownership

Allocation guidance: weight quota-carrying capacity toward pools 1-2 at roughly four-to-one against everything else. Pools 3-5 are relationship investments with multi-year fuses — staff them with senior coverage on partial goals, never with hunters who need this-year numbers.

3. The policy calendar — dated gates, 2026-2028

Run the team's operating rhythm against these dates — each one changes either what we can sell or how the buyer's math works.

DATE	EVENT	TEAM ACTION
Oct 1, 2026	NERC PRC-029-1 ride-through becomes enforceable (explicitly includes BESS)	Ride-through compliance evidence goes into every proof pack; verify PCS cert files are current
Dec 10, 2026	ERCOT Batch Zero target after the Abbott queue audit (BNEF: ~49.8 GW / up to \$15B at risk)	Expect Texas queue repricing; re-verify every forecast line that depends on a TX interconnection position
Dec 31, 2026	Treasury's PFE tables due (interim reliance runs 60 days past publication)	Re-run every MACR model on publication — customer-facing arithmetic goes stale overnight
Jan 1, 2027	MACR floor steps 55% → 60%; Dominion GS-5 rate class effective; NDAA "mined, refined, separated" expansion	Annual model refresh; the safe-harbor pool ages one build-season; brief the team on the new floor
Jul 2027	10-year recapture regime live (tax years beginning after Jul 4, 2027)	Audit every LTSA and service contract on safe-harbored accounts for effective-control exposure — short and non-exclusive, no exceptions
Oct 1, 2027	DoD §154 procurement ban effective	DoD-adjacency screen becomes a hard gate; close out any gray-zone pursuits with counsel before this date
Jan 1, 2028	FY2026 NDAA FEOC-free sourcing for new advanced-battery acquisitions; MACR floor → 65%	Defense-adjacent channel formally dead; floor step reduces modelable Lithium content again
2028	Georgia Power rate case (base-rate freeze expires); MACR floor → 65% in effect	Watch for the next certified-BESS tranche and whether third-party RFP volume grows
Rolling	NFPA 855-2026 state-by-state adoption; UL 9540A 5th-edition alignment	Keep large-scale fire-test (CSA TS-800) data and the NFPA 855 package current; AHJ acceptance is a deal-timing item

Also on the watchlist with unscheduled timing: the Ohio Supreme Court appeal of the AEP tariff (No. 2025-1458), the Louisiana stranded-cost fight, tariff-stack movement (it moved four times in 2026 — quarterly verification is mandatory), and any movement on the FCC's Chinese-equipment authorizations.

4. Competitive posture — rules of engagement

ON.energy — category rival, not customer (high-confidence dossier read). Its AI UPS is medium-voltage, ride-through-certified, FEOC-clean by design, and anchored by a 5 GW Crusoe deployment — every attribute the ∞Power AIDC line lacks for US hyperscale buyers. Do not chase the US AI UPS socket head-on. Watch three things: the **unnamed cell supplier** (a 5 GW award sets the sourcing norms for the whole BESS-as-UPS category), **Crusoe slippage** (the financing is unproven scaffolding — >\$250M lifetime capital against a 5 GW buildout; a shrunk program deflates the category's first-mover claim), and the **acquisition endgame** (a Vertiv/Eaton/Schneider-class buyer would instantly re-rate the category). One opening: the dormant LatAm franchise has a demonstrated history of buying Chinese cells and no FEOC constraint — a standing-watch channel for the non-US motion.

The gas cohort (VoltaGrid, ERock, ProEnergy, Mainspring) — demand-shapers, not rivals. Every campus they win defers a containerized-storage purchase, and all four carry zero BESS in-product: open attach sockets from ~2029. No

direct pursuit; track through their customers' owners, and expect FEOC optics to steer the sockets away from us unless the policy stack moves.

CATL — the in-lane rival. Same fence, same lanes, plus the litigation weapon (the Ningde suit). Win on availability, augmentation terms, and LDES-native duration (no mass-produced like-for-like above 1,000 Ah — policy risk is lowest where technical substitutability is lowest). The suit gets exactly one approved line in customer conversations (IC playbook §5); anything more goes through legal.

The FEOC-compliant tier (Tesla, Samsung SDI, LGES, US-assembled integrator stacks). Do not price-fight where the ITC is in the model — the lost credit swamps any cell delta and the room knows it. That pursuit-discipline rule is a forecast-integrity rule: any deal in the pipeline that requires beating Megapack inside an ITC model is a fiction; kill it.

Peak Energy — the account-level wedge. The Jupiter defense belongs to the account team (IC playbook §6); leadership owns the executive-sponsor cadence and the escalation path on the early-warning indicators. Treat any Peak delivery attributed on a Jupiter project as a leadership-level event, not an account-team note.

5. Pipeline metrics and forecasting discipline

Suggested stage gates — each stage has an exit criterion a deal must document, not assert:

STAGE	EXIT CRITERION
S1 · Lane verified	Safe-harbor evidence sighted (BOC documentation) or tax-indifference confirmed in the buyer's own model
S2 · Decision-map fit	We are talking to the party who signs the cell PO (per the channel map — owner, not EPC)
S3 · Technical qualification	Proof pack exchanged; security architecture accepted (Texas: no-remote-access posture agreed)
S4 · Commercial	TCO delivered with the tariff stack disclosed and date-stamped; MACR model delivered where the ITC is in play
S5 · Contracted	Signed supply agreement — not an MOU

Counting rules — enforced at every forecast review:

- **MOUs are optionality, never backlog.** The Samsung C&T lesson: a ~10 GWh cooperation agreement, publicly unconverted 19+ months on. Perfect Power's 1 GWh stays MOU-grade until deliveries attribute. An MOU enters the forecast at zero; conversion requires a PO or a delivery schedule.
- **The safe-harbor pool is a depletion asset.** Report coverage as *percentage of the enumerated list contacted and qualified*, not percentage of quota — the denominator is knowable and shrinking, and "we haven't found them all yet" is a coverage failure, not a market condition.
- **Certified-MW watchlist as the leading indicator.** Assign ownership of the IRP-docket and RFP calendar (Georgia's 500 MW ESS RFP and the ~1,000 MW signaled behind it; Entergy Louisiana's BESS RFP; PSO/SWEPCO all-source; Dominion's annual cycle) even where pool 3 carries no quota — certified MW today is the 2028-29 addressable map.
- **Quiet-buyer hygiene is a pipeline rule too:** account names never appear in internal decks that travel (board material, partner reviews) without the same written-consent standard the ICs carry externally.
- **Forecast the fence honestly.** Our US revenue is structurally lumpy and account-concentrated — a Jupiter-shaped book, not a logo wall. Don't smooth it; management above you should see the concentration risk, because the

mitigation (reference quality, augmentation annuities, the non-US book) is a strategy conversation, not a spreadsheet adjustment.

6. Team standards

- **Red lines are enforced, not advisory.** The IC playbook §8 list (never assert 2026+ ITC eligibility; never sign or facilitate non-PFE certifications; BOC representations through counsel; date-stamped tariff disclosure; 9540A / NOGRR / Tier 1 vocabulary discipline; Mesquite framing; quiet-buyer discretion; short non-exclusive service contracts) is the team's compliance floor. One vocabulary slip in front of a technical audience costs the room — treat deck review as seriously as contract review.
- **Banned talk tracks**, verbatim, in any setting: *"The Texas plant makes us FEOC-compliant"* (overclaims a tax outcome); *"We're cheaper than Tesla"* where the ITC applies; any precise tariff total without a date stamp.
- **Field intel flows into the Profiler notes pipeline** with a rated confidence score — and field notes are never cited as profile sources. The dossier base is the shared memory; a deal insight that dies in a rep's notebook is a team loss.
- **Proof-pack maintenance has a named owner** and a quarterly refresh cycle: tariff-stack verification, CATL-suit status, IPO/financing status, US fleet performance data. Stale numbers in a bankability conversation are worse than no numbers.
- **Counsel routing is a workflow, not an escalation.** Any document touching MACR percentages, FEOC status, or BOC evidence goes through legal before it leaves the building — build the template library once so the routing is fast.

7. The 2026-28 play, one page

2026 H2 — harvest and defend. Enumerate the safe-harbored list to exhaustion and work it with dedicated hunters. Defend Jupiter with the augmentation lock and the BOC-service play; treat any Peak delivery on a Jupiter project as a leadership event. Run merchant ERCOT with the security-architecture lead. Seed the Southeast AVL/IE relationships that pay in 2028-29. Re-run every MACR model when Treasury's tables land (Dec 31 + 60 days).

2027 — the narrowing. The floor steps to 60%, recapture goes live (audit the LTSA book before July), and the DoD gate shuts in October. The US ITC-compatible book is whatever safe-harbored projects are still building; merchant ERCOT and augmentation carry the run rate; the non-US book carries growth. Watch ON.energy's cell-supplier reveal — it prices the whole BESS-as-UPS category's sourcing norms — and the first gas-cohort storage sockets going to tender.

2028 — the pivot signals. MACR at 65% and FEOC-free defense phasing make the US ITC lane effectively shut for our content. The surviving US business is merchant, augmentation annuities, and reference-fleet services — plus whatever the policy stack does next (an election-cycle variable we track, not predict). The strategic decision that matters — localized cell production, a licensing structure, or holding the merchant/non-US line — is above sales; **our job is to surface the signals upward early**: safe-harbor pool exhaustion rate, merchant price realization vs the compliant tier, the gas-socket tender outcomes, and the regulated Southeast's third-party RFP volume.

We assess (moderate confidence): if the team executes pools 1-2 with discipline and keeps the Jupiter reference intact, the 2026-28 US book is defensible without a single policy break going our way — and every policy break that does come (a tariff-stack cut, a MACR table surprise, a FEOC amendment) lands on an organization already positioned at the front of the affected lane.

Hithium — Team-Lead Playbook · Internal, sales strategy · Rendered from hithium-team-lead-playbook.md, which remains the source of truth · Developed by: ShadowAISolutions